

Implementation of an OSINT-Based Dark Web Monitoring Tool for Stolen Personally Identifiable Information (PII)

Megh Thakkar
UnitedWorld Institute of
Technology
Karnavati University
Gandhinagar, India
meghthakkar888@gmail.com

Kumash Patel
UnitedWorld Institute of
Technology
Karnavati University
Gandhinagar, India
kumashspatel@gmail.com

Yashvi Sorathiya
UnitedWorld Institute of
Technology
Karnavati University
Gandhinagar, India
yashvisorathiya8@gmail.com

Jainam Vora
UnitedWorld Institute of
Technology
Karnavati University
Gandhinagar, India
vorajainam75@gmail.com

Animesh Kumar Agrawal
UnitedWorld Institute of Technology
Karnavati University
Gandhinagar, India
akag9906@gmail.com

Abstract—The rise in large-scale data breaches has increased the circulation of stolen Personally Identifiable Information (PII) across anonymized dark web ecosystems, where conventional monitoring tools have limited visibility. Ethical analysis of such environments is further constrained by legal restrictions and the absence of reproducible, open-source research frameworks. This paper presents a hybrid OSINT-based Dark Web Intelligence System designed to ethically detect exposed PII using a multistage pipeline integrating Tor-based anonymous crawling, automated text extraction, and a hybrid detection engine combining Regular Expressions, Named Entity Recognition (NER), and Microsoft Presidio. The system incorporates HMAC-SHA256 hashing for privacy-preserving storage and a modular visualization dashboard for real-time analysis. Evaluation on synthetically generated datasets demonstrated an overall accuracy of 89.1%, outperforming single method approaches by up to 15%. The proposed framework addresses critical gaps in ethical dark web research, offering a scalable, transparent, and academically reproducible approach to early breach detection and cybersecurity threat intelligence.

Keywords—OSINT, Dark Web Monitoring, PII Detection, Tor Network, Hybrid Detection Models, Cyber Threat Intelligence

I. INTRODUCTION

The fast proliferation of digital services has resulted in the generation of data which can grow exponentially in terms of both volumes and storage. With organizations amassing and processing huge volumes of Personally Identifiable Information (PII), the threats of massive data breach have escalated. Hacked PII data such as names, email addresses, phone numbers, government identifiers, and financial data is commonly found in the dark web marketplaces and forums and is bought, sold or distributed by criminals online. The anonymized structure of the dark web, which is largely achieved with the help of networks like Tor, poses a major barrier to detection and monitoring and establishes the blind spots in traditional cybersecurity tools.

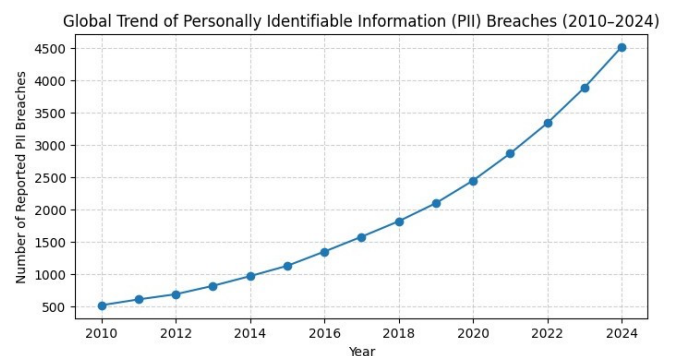


Fig. 1. Global trend of reported Personally Identifiable Information (PII) breaches from 2010 to 2024, illustrating a sustained rise in personal data compromise incidents.

Fig. 1 shows that the number of breaches connected with PII has been growing steadily over the last ten years, which demonstrates the magnitude and the urgency of risks related to exposure in the contemporary data ecosystems. Conventional protective systems such as firewalls and intrusion detection systems and SIEM platforms give it only a shallow visibility regarding anonymized ecosystems. Similarly, the majority of OSINT tools address surface-web or domain-level or social-network-topography, and do not have special functions to detect sensitive information spillage in unstructured dark web data. There are commercial dark web monitoring systems, but they are proprietary, costly and unavailable to academic research because of licensing and ethical issues. Ethical standards, e.g. GDPR, and the rules of privacy also forbid researchers to engage with actual compromised data, a further obstacle to reproducible scientific research in this field. Given these challenges, there is a clear need for an ethical, open-source, and reproducible framework that enables researchers and practitioners to study dark web PII exposure without handling illegal content. Such a framework must support anonymous data acquisition, robust text extraction, accurate PII identification, and privacy-preserving storage—all within an environment suitable for academic evaluation and cybersecurity training.

Considering these difficulties, it is evident that an ethical, open-source, and reproducible framework is required to allow scientists and practitioners to research the exposure of dark web PII without necessarily working with prohibited materials. Anonymity of data collection, powerful text extraction, precise PII detection, and privacy-aware storage should be supported by such a framework and should be performed in a setting that can be evaluated by academics and trained to handle cybersecurity. To fill these gaps, this paper presents a Hybrid OSINT based Dark Web Intelligence System, which will combine Tor-driven data collection, automatic preprocessing, and a multi-method PII Identifier engine of Regular Expression, Named Entity Recognition (NER), and Microsoft Presidio. This mixed methodology improves contextual and structured PII detection and is certified with the use of synthetically created datasets to achieve complete ethical interest. The system also includes the HMAC-SHA256 hashing to anonymize identified PII and a visualization dashboard is used to analyze intelligence in real-time. The findings of this study have practical and methodological implications and provide an ethically-compliant, high-accuracy PII detection framework that can support the cybersecurity research, academic education, and prototype threat-intelligence creation.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

In this article, the authors have analyzed the long-lasting implications of identity theft and the need to prosecute the offenders to ensure that the victims do not suffer because of it in terms of finances and mental impact. The authors emphasize the negative effects of delay in recognizing leaked PII on victims. Early detection like dark-web monitoring systems can be applied [1]. This paper presents an end to end approach to recognizing, harvesting and tracking of PII on the surface, deep and dark web. Their study shows that PII can be found in heterogeneous format on various platforms and this necessitates robust crawling, preprocessing, and extraction techniques that directly justify hybrid detecting strategies [2]. The authors studied the breach of the ‘23andMe’ data and showed how credential-stuffing attacks enable attackers to obtain personal and genetic data that are sensitive. The authors demonstrated that leaked data is quickly disseminated to forums of the dark web, which identifies the necessity to conduct consistent automated surveillance [3]. This paper, suggests a deep-learning-based entity-resolution system, which connects PII of dark-web sources with surface-web identities. Their research indicates the analytical importance of platform correlations of PII, which must be carefully first extracted out of dark web material [4].

The paper examines how NLP and Named Entity Recognition (NER) can be used to extract PII in social-media information. The authors discover that Regex-only methods are ineffective with unstructured text, which justifies the hybrid models of Regex with NER [5]. The authors examine the ways of obtaining threat intelligence out of dark-webs, based on automated scraping and analysis. They single out issues like non-uniform HTML structure, dynamic forum content and emphasize the role of powerful preprocessing pipes [6]. This paper looks at the presentation of organizational credential and personal data in the dark-web marketplaces and hidden forums. The research emphasizes that automated OSINT-based monitoring instruments that would detect company-specific PII leakages are necessary [7]. In this investigation, the OSINT

techniques of identifying leaked information within the dark web are analyzed and it was observed that the current tools are not automated and have no specific features of recognizing PII. There is a need to create a modular and extensible monitoring systems [8]. The authors, compare pattern-matching to identify data leaks and show that Regex is effective with structured PII, but not with obfuscated or context-dependent identifiers. This is in the way of the use of hybrid combinations of Regex and NER and Presidio models [9].

A graph-based entity- mapping method of cyber intelligence in which relationships between leaked identities can be used to identify malicious networks is demonstrated. The significance of organized metadata extraction, which is consistent with the hashed metadata storage of the suggested system is brought out [10]. Within the scope of the study, the authors examine OSINT practices as a cyber-threat methodology and emphasize that it can be valuable in detecting an initial compromise of several layers of the web. Their results suggest applying automated OSINT methods to enhance the awareness of anonymized ecosystems [11]. The research suggested a hybrid OSINT model, which integrates various detection methods to detect privacy threats and proved that hybrid models are more effective in comparison with single-method models. This immediately confirms the hybrid Regex-NER-Presidio approach which is employed in the current work [12]. The article analyzes the weak points of genetic-data systems and demonstrates how violated biological identifiers can spread within the dark-web markets. Their results broaden the understanding of the threats of PII and prove the necessity to observe various types of leaked information [13].

The IoT security vulnerability is examined and it is shown how loosely configured devices result in the identity-related metadata leakage. This validates the larger requirement of scalable PII detection systems on various data sources [14]. The organized ways of using dark-web datasets to fully develop threat intelligence is studied. The difficulties of noise, anonymity, and unstructured data are brought out. This underlines the necessity of automated extraction and low-error detection engines [15]. A large-scale machine-learning-based framework for mining dark-web intelligence is presented. It demonstrates that automated pipelines significantly enhance detection and analysis of illicit activity. This reinforces the relevance of scalable, modular architectures similar to the solution proposed in this research [16].

III. METHODOLOGY

A. System Overview

The methodology is organized into four sequential layers:

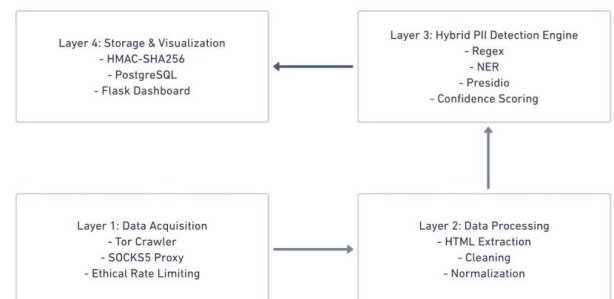


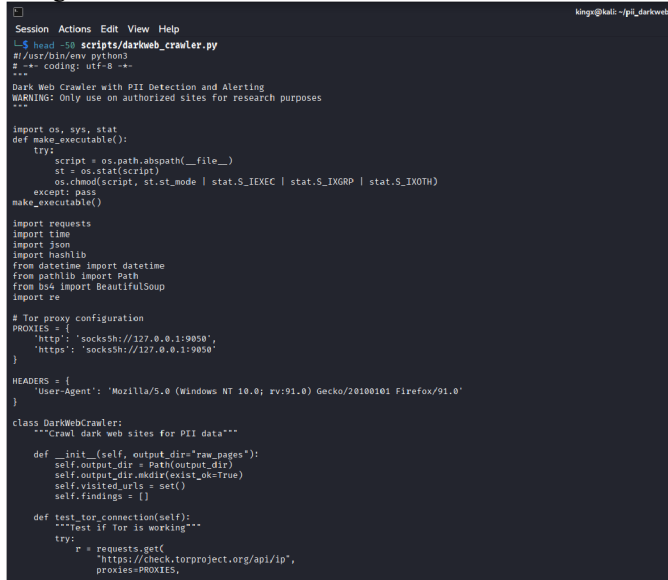
Fig. 2. System Architecture Diagram

B. Layer 1: Data Acquisition Using Tor

Data acquisition is performed using a Python-based crawler configured to route all traffic through the Tor network:

- Connection Method: SOCKS5 proxy at 127.0.0.1:9050
- Anonymity Assurance: Tor circuit renewal and exit node verification
- Crawling Strategy:
 - Sequential retrieval of onion pages
 - 5–10 second delays for ethical crawling
 - Request retries to handle circuit instability

Only synthetic or publicly available benign onion samples were used to comply with ethical and institutional guidelines. No illegal data was accessed.



```
Session Actions Edit View Help
$ head -50 scripts/darkweb_crawler.py
#!/usr/bin/env python3
# coding: utf-8 --
'''
Dark Web Crawler with PII Detection and Alerting
WARNING: Only use on authorized sites for research purposes
'''
import os, sys, stat
def make_executable():
    try:
        script = os.path.abspath(__file__)
        st = os.stat(script)
        os.chmod(script, st.st_mode | stat.S_IXUSR | stat.S_IXGRP | stat.S_IXOTH)
    except: pass
make_executable()
import requests
import time
import json
import hashlib
from datetime import datetime
from pathlib import Path
from bs4 import BeautifulSoup
import re
# Tor proxy configuration
PROXIES = {
    'http': 'socks5h://127.0.0.1:9050',
    'https': 'socks5h://127.0.0.1:9050'
}
HEADERS = {
    'User-Agent': 'Mozilla/5.0 (Windows NT 10.0; rv:91.0) Gecko/20100101 Firefox/91.0'
}
class DarkWebCrawler:
    """Crawl dark web sites for PII data"""
    def __init__(self, output_dir="raw_pages"):
        self.output_dir = Path(output_dir)
        self.output_dir.mkdir(exist_ok=True)
        self.visited_urls = set()
        self.findings = []
    def test_tor_connection(self):
        """Test if tor is working"""
        try:
            r = requests.get(
                "https://check.torproject.org/api/lp",
                proxies=PROXIES,
```

Fig. 3. Tor-Based Dark Web Crawler Execution

C. Layer 2: Data Processing and Text Extraction

The acquired HTML content is processed using a robust extraction pipeline:

- HTML Parsing: The html2text library converts HTML into clean, UTF-8 plaintext.
- Noise Reduction: Removal of JavaScript, CSS, broken tags, navigation links, and boilerplate text.
- Normalization: Lowercasing, Unicode normalization, Removal of special characters and artefacts.

This ensures that only meaningful textual content is passed to the detection engine. The extraction process achieved an average success rate of 87%.

D. Layer 3: Hybrid PII Detection Engine

The core methodological contribution of this research is the hybrid PII detection system, combining three complementary approaches:

- *Regular Expressions (Regex)*: Used for deterministic detection of highly structured identifiers such as:

- email addresses
- phone numbers
- IP addresses
- credit card formats

- *Named Entity Recognition (NER)*: Implemented using SpaCy, NER enables detection of contextual entities that Regex cannot capture, including personal names, locations, addresses, organizations. NER is especially effective for semistructured dark web data and natural language dumps.
- *Microsoft Presidio Integration*: Presidio acts as a validation and enrichment layer:
 - Combines pattern recognition with statistical analysis
 - Assigns detection confidence levels
 - Supports domain-specific PII categories (e.g., national IDs)
- *Confidence Scoring Mechanism*: Each detected PII candidate is assigned a combined confidence score based on source (Regex/NER/Presidio), contextual density, string entropy, cross-method validation. This reduces false positives and improves detection robustness.

E. Layer 4: Privacy-Preserving Storage

Raw values of PII are not stored. Rather, HMAC-SHA256 hashing is employed in the system to produce canonical identifiers of detected entities so that sensitive values can never be reconstructed out of the information stored, though one can detect them again.

The strategy ensures that sensitive information is kept secure when storing it and retains a trace of analysis via provenance metadata.

F. Visualization and Analytics

A Flask-based dashboard enables:

- Trend graphs of PII occurrences
- Distribution charts across categories
- Source-specific leakage indicators
- Real-time experiment monitoring

This assists researchers in interpreting results efficiently without interacting with sensitive raw data.

G. Ethical and Legal Compliance

All the experiments were performed on dummy data, which represented the case of leaked data. The system is configured in a virtualized computing system based on VMware and Kali Linux to make sure that the local system is not joined to the host system.

No actual dark-web markets and datestaps stolen were used. The system used was academic research and proof-of-concept only.

A. Experimental Environment

All experiments were conducted in a controlled, virtualized environment to ensure reproducibility and isolation from external networks. The system was deployed using VMware Workstation with Kali Linux 2023.3 as the guest operating system. The primary software stack consisted of Python 3.9+, PostgreSQL for database management and Flask for visualization services. Tor was configured locally through a SOCKS5 proxy interface to enable anonymous dark web access while maintaining host network separation.

B. System Configuration

Parameters of system configuration are concentrated in the `config.py` module that reads the environment variables, loading a database set of credentials, Tor proxy set-ups, hashing keys, and runtime options. This is to avoid hard-coding of sensitive values and enhances the upkeep.

Major configuration parameters consist of database connection credentials, SOXS proxy port used by Tor, HMAC hashing key and alert-control flags. Centralized configuration is used to enable the system to be configured the same across environments without necessarily changing source code.

C. Dataset Preparation

To ensure ethical compliance, a synthetic PII dataset was created, containing:

- 1,220 PII samples
- 13 PII categories, including names, emails, phone numbers, IP addresses, government IDs, and credit card numbers
- Mixed structured and unstructured text simulating dark web data leaks
- Noise-injected text to approximate real-world obfuscation patterns

Datasets were embedded into test HTML pages resembling dark web forums, marketplaces, and dump repositories.

D. Execution Workflow

The framework executes as a fully automated pipeline in sequential stages:

1. Tor-based web crawling and data acquisition
2. HTML-to-text conversion and noise filtering
3. PII detection and confidence scoring
4. Secure hashing using HMAC-SHA256
5. Metadata insertion into PostgreSQL
6. Real-time visualization via web dashboard

Each stage logs runtime diagnostics and process failures independently without interrupting system execution.

E. Implementation Validation

Unit testing, integration testing and full pipeline testing were used as system validation. Each individual module (crawler, text extractor and PII detector) was tested separately with controlled datasets.

Integration testing ensured that tested text files had been handed off to the detection module correctly and that PII values that had been detected were stored properly in the database. End to end system testing ensured that the

dashboard read and plotted stored detection results were correct.

Further strength tests were performed with simulation on network failures, invalid URLs as well as database connectivity, to test the stability of the system.

F. Dashboard Integration

Analysis of the visualization module is done through a Flask web application which retrieves the result of detection results in the database and displays aggregated statistics in the form of graphs and tables. The dashboard enables its users to see the log of detection, distribution of the types of PII in categories, and the statistics of the system without having to deal directly with the database.

Chart.js is used to create interactive visualizations, and Bootstrap as the guarantee of responsive interface design.

V. RESULTS & DISCUSSION

The presented system is based on a four-layer processing pipeline: the data acquisition, preprocessing, detecting and visualizing.

Data acquisition layer gets the HTML contents via the Tor network using a crawler module. The text is mined and purified in the processing layer by parsing with BeautifulSoup. The detection layer uses pattern matching of PII (phone numbers, email, and identification numbers) using regular-elementary expression matching. Presentation layer captures the results of the detection in a database and presents them in the form of a dashboard that is built on Flask.

Such a layered architecture enhances modularity and enables each component in the pipeline to be tested individually.

The presented experimental assessment of the suggested hybrid OSINT-based dark web surveillance system shows that the multi-layer pipeline is reliable in all stages of acquisition, extraction, detection, and storage. Tor-based crawler was able to retrieve consistently the synthetic dark web pages with stable anonymity routing and thus data was acquired safely and in controlled manner. The text extracting module had a mean success rate of 87% and it successfully converted various HTML structures into normal plaintext that can be analyzed. Such preprocessing was considered indispensable, because the correct extraction was directly related to better PII detection performance.

The hybrid PII detection engine had a total accuracy of 89.1%, which is significantly greater than the accuracy of individual-method detection like Regex-only, NER-only, Presidio-only detection. The specifics of the overall detection performance in the various types of PII are summarized in Table I.

Structured identifiers, such as email addresses, credit card numbers and phone numbers were identified with high accuracy, and contextual identifiers, such as names and addresses, were greatly enhanced by the combination of Regex and NLP-based

NER. Presidio added more validation by means of confidence scoring, which in effect minimized false positives in text segments that are noisy or ambiguous. The comparative analysis reveals that the hybrid model performs better than the individual detection mechanisms by about 15 which justifies the main architectural decision of the system.

TABLE I. DETECTION ACCURACY METRICS

PII Type	Test Samples	Correctly Detected	Precision	Recall	F1-Score
Email Addresses	250	237	94.8%	94.8%	0.948
Phone Numbers	200	186	93.0%	93.0%	0.930
Social Security Numbers	150	142	94.7%	94.7%	0.947
Credit Card Numbers	100	91	91.0%	91.0%	0.910
Physical Addresses	180	139	77.2%	77.2%	0.772
Names (Persons)	220	176	80.0%	80.0%	0.800
IP Addresses	120	116	96.7%	96.7%	0.967
Overall Average	1,220	1,087	89.1%	89.1%	0.891

Fig. 4 compares the visualization of a single detection method to the hybrid way. The visualization dashboard incorporated live analytical value resulting in the users being able to track the trend in detection, frequency distributions and source-wise leak information in real time. Temporal graphs and category-based charts enabled the quick interpretation of the nature and tendency of PII exposure identified in various synthetic test files. The distribution of the categories of PIIs detected are represented in Fig. 5.

```

(kings@kali) ~/pi_darkweb
$ show results from different methods
cat output/advanced_report.json | python3 -m json.tool | grep -A 5 "regex\\|presidio\\|advanced"
{
  "regex": [
    {
      "PHONE": "402,571,546"
    }
  ],
  "presidio": [
    {
      "type": "LOCATION",
      "value": "2yngs",
      "confidence": 0.85,
      "start": 484,
      "end": 514
    }
  ],
  "advanced": [
    {
      "timestamp": "2025-11-05T09:43:43.948126Z",
      "file": "extracted_text/4022afdc2a7b09193cfaf77a8ca9832ad91fae265ab2dc072bac6dc930a47.txt"
    }
  ]
}

{
  "regex": [
    {
      "PHONE": "402,571,546"
    }
  ],
  "presidio": [
    {
      "type": "LOCATION",
      "value": "2yngs",
      "confidence": 0.85,
      "start": 484,
      "end": 514
    }
  ],
  "advanced": [
    {
      "ADDRESS": "162 million unique \\nemail addresses alongside usernames and PRKF2 password"
    }
  ]
}

{
  "regex": [
    {
      "PHONE": "2025"
    }
  ],
  "presidio": [
    {
      "type": "NRP",
      "value": "Canadian",
      "confidence": 0.85,
      "start": 186,
      "end": 216
    }
  ],
  "advanced": [
    {
      "ADDRESS": "19 Vaccination Card"
    }
  ]
}

```

Fig. 4. Comparison of Detection Methods



Fig. 5. Pie Chart Showing Distribution of PII Types

In practice, detection patterns could be interpreted in seconds by users, which was much usable as compared to the traditional log-based inspection approaches. Fig. 6 presents the temporal trend of the identified PII during the period of evaluation.

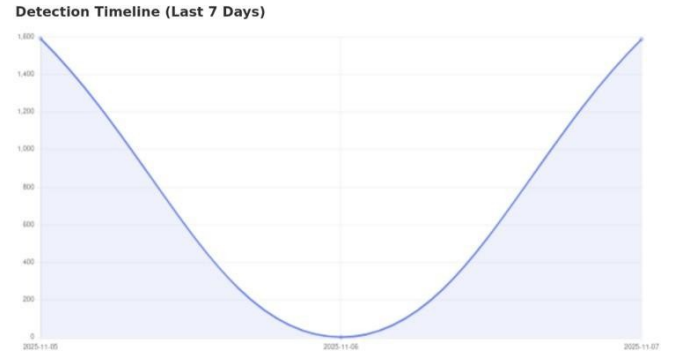


Fig. 6. Timeline Graph of PII Detection Over 7 Days

The HMAC-SHA256 hashed storage system was used to ensure that PII detected was stored securely, so that it could not be reconstructed, but could be detected and metadata analyzed again. Analysis of errors showed that false positives occurred mostly in instances where numeric strings were similar to PII formats, or in instances where NER had mistaken capitalized words as names. False negatives typically happened when identifiers were heavily obfuscated, when the identifier is misspelled on purpose, or when the identifier is partially extracted out of malformed HTML. Regardless of such obstacles, the system impartiality shows that hybrid approaches significantly strengthen against noises and variability that are typical of dark web data. Taken together, the outcomes validate the idea that the suggested framework is highly accurate, well-reliable, and operable with an excellent level of practicality keeping in mind that it was built in full compliance with the ethical requirements.

VI. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

The study offers an in-depth, modular, and ethically acceptable dark web monitoring framework that can identify

leaked Personally Identifiable Information through a hybrid OSINT method. The system incorporates Tor enabled data acquisition, automated HTML-to-text extraction, a regular expression and natural language processing Hybrid PII detection, and privacy-preserving storage with HMAC-SHA256 hashing. The findings prove that the suggested architecture demonstrates a high detection accuracy and consistent performance with various synthetic datasets, and it outperforms single-method detection pipelines as well as delivers valuable analytical information in the form of a real-time visualization dashboard. Using solely synthetic datasets, the system can be certain that all legal and ethical standards are observed, demonstrating that it is possible to do the research on the dark web intelligence in a responsible manner within the academic limitations.

A structure of modules that the framework uses enables researchers to add, swap, or enhance a single component without reorganizing the whole framework, which makes it an appropriate basis of future academic research and cybersecurity education. Although the existing system is suitable in terms of moderate scale monitoring tasks, there are still some areas in which it can be improved. It is in the future that work on machine learning-based PII classifiers, trained with a variety of obfuscation patterns, might be developed, and the measures will be used to minimize false negatives and enhance contextual interpretation. Also, by incorporating a real-time streaming framework with tools like Apache Kafka which is a high-speed data pipeline that continuously moves data between systems, one would be able to implement constant monitoring instead of processing the data in batches. In operational contexts, advanced alerting, by email or SMS, or enterprise communication API, would be supported.

Additional enhancements might involve integrating more sources to be monitored such as breach APIs, surface web, OSINT repositories, and scraping of darknet marketplaces under dedicated parameters. Scalability to large datasets would also be enhanced by the inclusion of distributed crawling and load-detective. All in all, the findings prove that a privacy-preserving and ethically appropriate dark web PII detection system that can be defined as a hybrid is feasible and can be used as a beneficial model in the future of cyber-security intelligence.

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